



NEWLY ELECTED Pope Leo XIV, center, leaves the Sistine Chapel at the Vatican after celebrating his first Mass as pontiff with the College of the Cardinals on Friday. His formal installation Mass is set for May 18.

After conclave, cardinals detail election of Pope Leo

Many marvel at how quickly an American was able to collect the necessary votes. One archbishop even called it ‘a miracle.’

By Nicole Winfield

VATICAN CITY — Pope Leo XIV said Friday that his election was both a cross to bear and a blessing as he celebrated his first Mass and details began to emerge of how votes swiftly coalesced to make him history’s first American pope.

Freed from their conclave, cardinals began de-

scribing the hours leading up to the final ballot Thursday afternoon that brought Leo past the two-thirds majority needed. Many marveled that the Chicago-born Augustinian missionary Robert Prevost reached the threshold so quickly, given the vast diversity of voters and the traditional taboo against a U.S. pope because of the secular power the country wields.

“It is a miracle of the Holy Spirit,” said Cardinal Fernando Natalio Chomali Garib, archbishop of Santiago, Chile. He noted that 133 men who barely knew one another from 70 countries came to an agreement in just over 24 hours. A miracle, he said, “and also an example for all our countries where nobody comes to an agreement.”

Leo presided over his

first Mass before those same cardinal electors Friday morning, speaking off-the-cuff in English in the Sistine Chapel. He acknowledged the great responsibility they had placed on him before delivering a brief but dense homily in Italian on the need to joyfully spread Christianity in a world that often mocks it.

“You have called me to

[See Pontiff, A4]

New soil testing finds high levels of toxic metals

L.A. County collects samples at properties ravaged by wildfires and cleaned up by Army Corps crews.

By Tony Briscoe and Hayley Smith

New soil testing by the Los Angeles County Department of Public Health has found high levels of lead and other toxic metals at homes destroyed by January’s catastrophic wildfires and cleared by federal cleanup crews.

The county health department hired Roux Associates Inc. to conduct soil sampling at 30 homesites that had been cleaned up by the U.S. Army Corps of Engineers — the federal agency leading debris-removal operations for the Eaton and Palisades wildfires. The Army Corps and Federal Emergency Management Agency have said crews would clear wildfire debris and up to 6 inches of topsoil in ash-covered portions of the property.

In the Eaton burn scar, in the areas scraped by federal cleanup crews, around 27% of the Roux soil samples still had lead levels above California’s state standards for residential properties (80 milligrams per kilogram). In samples taken from parts of those properties where soil was not excavated, nearly 44% had lead levels above the state benchmark.

In the Palisades fire zone, the numbers were much more assuring: Less than 3% of soil samples from scraped portions of properties and about 12% from unscraped

areas had elevated lead levels.

Adam Love, the vice president and principal scientist for Roux, said the higher percentage of older homes with lead paint in Altadena, where the Eaton fire primarily hit, could be one of the reasons for the large disparity.

“The honest answer is we don’t know all the things that could be contributing to [the variation in lead contamination],” Love said. “It could be related to the difference in the housing stock, and the fact that the houses in the Eaton area are more likely to have lead-based paint.”

“It could be from soils during the scrape that got

[See Soil, A10]

Groups in state reeling as EPA ends grants

California projects would have included clean drinking water, a park and air purifiers.

By Hayley Smith

After weeks of speculation, the news came down with chilling formality:

“Dear EPA Grant Recipient,” read the official government email. “Attached is your Termination of Award from the U.S. Environmental Protection Agency.”

That’s how hundreds of organizations found out they had officially lost EPA grant funding as part of the many cutbacks to environmental programs demanded by the Trump administration.

Among them was the Community Water Center, a nonprofit that works to provide safe, clean drinking water to rural communities in California. Its \$20-million award had been earmarked for a major project to consolidate water systems in the low-income Central Coast communities of Pajaro, Sunny Mesa and Springfield, which have long been reliant on domestic wells and small water systems with contaminants above legal limits.

The project was more than five years in the making and now sits in limbo as President Trump and EPA Administrator Lee Zeldin slash funding for more than 780 grants geared toward environmental justice that were awarded under President Biden.

“It’s a huge disappointment — this grant would be funding an infrastructure project to deliver safe drinking water, and I think that everyone would agree that residents across the United States need to have safe

[See EPA, A8]

Budget proposal cuts hiring of police

Committee backs a plan that would leave the LAPD with about 300 fewer officers.

By Noah Goldberg and David Zahniser

Faced with a projected \$1-billion shortfall, a key committee of the Los Angeles City Council moved forward Thursday with a plan to reduce the number of police officers and cancel Mayor Karen Bass’ plan for creating a homelessness unit within the Fire Department.

The council’s five-member budget committee voiced initial support for a slowdown in hiring that would leave the Los Angeles Police Department with about 8,400 officers by June 30, 2026, down from more than 8,700 this year and about 10,000 in 2020.

The move, if approved by the full City Council later this month, would be part of a much larger effort to restore positions targeted for elimination in the mayor’s \$14-billion proposed budget.

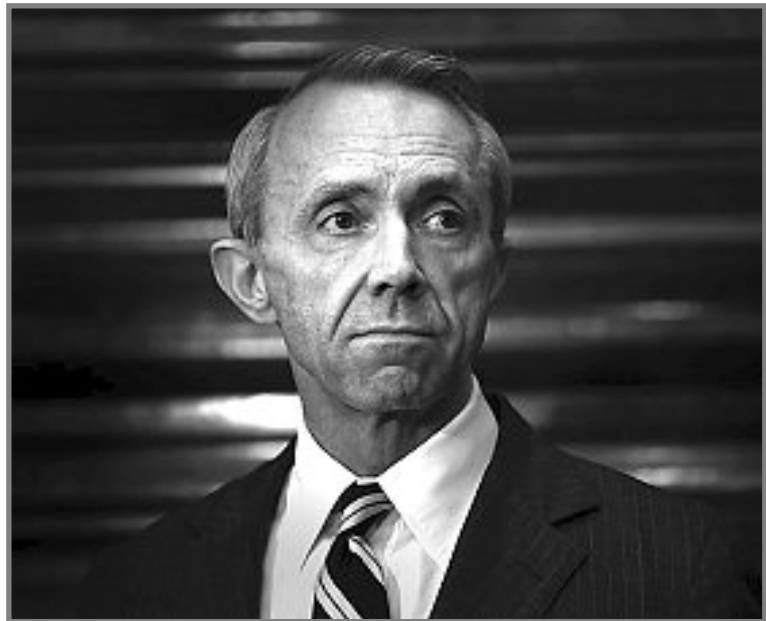
The slowdown in police hiring would leave the LAPD with its lowest level of sworn staffing since 1995. But it would help save the jobs of

[See Officers, A8]

DAVID H. SOUTER, 1939 – 2025

New England Republican who became Supreme Court liberal

Scholarly jurist had key roles in civil rights, abortion cases



DAVID HUME KENNERLY Getty Images

‘A JUDGE’S JUDGE’

David H. Souter, seen in 2003, was not the first justice to surprise the president who nominated him, but he may be among the last.

By David G. Savage
Reporting from Washington

Retired Supreme Court Justice David H. Souter, the shy and frugal small-town New Englander who was touted as a conservative but surprised his Republican backers and nearly everyone else by becoming a staunch liberal on the high court, has died, the court said in a statement Friday. He was 85.

Souter stepped down in 2009 after nearly two decades on the court where he cast key votes to uphold laws on campaign finance, environmental protection, civil rights and church-state separation. He also played a crucial role in upholding a woman’s right to choose abortion in 1992.

Chief Justice John G. Roberts Jr. said in a statement that “Justice Souter served our court with great distinction for nearly 20 years. He brought uncommon wisdom and kindness to a lifetime of public service.”

Souter often said he liked the court

[See Souter, A6]

Judge releases Turkish student

Tufts PhD candidate seized on street by ICE agents will try to reintegrate. **NATION, A5**

Afrikaners gain refugee status

The U.S. will welcome white South Africans as other programs remain paused. **NATION, A12**

Computer glitch cripples BART

Service is restored, but not before thousands in Bay Area are left stranded. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather

Hot.
L.A. Basin: 93/64. **B8**

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